

NASA

Business Development Dossier

Industry	Federal Agency
Revenue	\$24.8B
Employees	14,000
Ideal Customer Profile Score	80

ICP SCORING MODEL



ICP = Signals + Revenue + Employees + Fit (max 100)

Signals (0-35)	Top 4 signals scored; each = base(60%) + recency bonus <30d: 40% <90d: 30% <180d: 20% older: 10%
Revenue (0-25)	\$500M-\$10B sweet spot -> 70-100% of 25 pts Below \$500M -> pro-rata x 0.5 Above \$10B -> 60%
Employees (0-20)	2,000+ preferred (70-100%) 500-2K partial (50-70%) Below 500 -> pro-rata x 0.3
Fit (0-20)	High-fit types: reorg, transformation, M&A, hiring, funding, partnership -> 5 pts ea (max 12) + diversity 2/type (max 8)

Prepared March 26, 2026

McChrystal Group

Leadership Advisory & Organizational Effectiveness

SECTION 1

Organization Snapshot

Legal Name National Aeronautics and Space Administration

Headquarters 300 E Street SW, Washington, D.C. 20546

Founded 1958

Ownership

Independent federal agency of the United States executive branch

Footprint

10 field centers: Johnson (Houston), Kennedy (FL), Marshall (AL), Goddard (MD), JPL (CA), Ames (CA), Glenn (OH), Langley (VA), Stennis (MS), Armstrong (CA). International partnerships with ESA, JAXA, CSA

SECTION 1b

Company Overview

NASA is the U.S. federal agency responsible for space exploration, aeronautics, and science, operating on a \$24.4 billion congressional budget with ~14,000 remaining employees after a 20% workforce exodus. Under new Administrator Jared Isaacman (confirmed December 2025), NASA is executing 'Project Athena' - a sweeping reorganization including program restructuring (Artemis redesigned, Gateway paused, \$20B moon base plan), contractor-to-civil-service conversion, and a pivot to commercial partnerships. The agency faces its most severe disruption in decades alongside active internal dissent (287 scientists signed the 'Voyager Declaration' warning of safety risks).

SECTION 2

Financial Health & Growth Stage

Understanding NASA's financial position and trajectory is critical to framing any engagement conversation.

Budget: \$24.4B FY2026 (congressional allocation, down from \$24.8B FY2025). White House proposed \$18.8B (24% cut, smallest since 1961) - Congress rejected with bipartisan 82-15 Senate vote

Key dynamics: Science Mission Directorate was targeted for 47% cut; Congress preserved most science funding. Artemis has ~\$6B in cost overruns and 6+ years of schedule delays per OIG

Contract terminations: \$420M in consulting contracts cancelled (Booz Allen, Deloitte, Guidehouse, McKinsey - none had been funded)

Infrastructure: Goddard campus consolidating (13 buildings closing, 25% reduction)

Trajectory: Shifting from government-funded operations toward commercial partnerships (SpaceX, Blue Origin for lunar landers; buying data from commercial providers)

SECTION 3

Leadership Team Profiles

The following contacts are recommended as primary outreach targets - champion-level leaders who feel the organizational pain daily and can sponsor McChrystal internally.

Amit Kshatriya - Associate Administrator (COO) [PRIORITY TARGET]

NASA's highest-ranking civil servant. Exploration-focused (Moon-to-Mars program veteran). Selected by Acting Administrator Duffy

Outreach rationale: Operational leader implementing Isaacman's vision across 10 centers with a depleted workforce. Manages day-to-day transformation that McChrystal's operating model addresses

Janet Petro - Director, Kennedy Space Center [PRIORITY TARGET]

U.S. Army veteran (retired Colonel). Former acting NASA Administrator (Jan-Jul 2025). Manages Artemis launch facility

Outreach rationale: Military veteran with institutional credibility - bridges McChrystal's military roots with NASA's civilian culture. Manages center where Artemis II is grounded

Additional leadership team members relevant to the engagement:

Jared Isaacman - NASA Administrator

Billionaire entrepreneur: founded Shift4 Payments at 16, founded Draken International (military adversary air training for USAF/NATO). Commercial astronaut: Inspiration4, Polaris Dawn (first private spacewalk). 7,000+ military jet flight hours. No government experience

Casey Swails - Deputy Associate Administrator

Advisor for day-to-day operations and long-term strategic direction across 10 centers

Tom Cremins - Associate Administrator for Space Security Interests

Military/intelligence background [INFERRED from role]

SECTION 4

Organizational Culture & Structure

Culture and structure are often where McChrystal Group finds the deepest leverage. The following signals indicate how NASA operates today and where friction exists.

Organizational Structure

Matrix organization: 10 geographically distributed field centers with significant autonomy, cross-cut by mission directorates (Science, Exploration, Space Operations, Aeronautics, Space Technology, Mission Support). Creates chronic center-vs-headquarters tension and duplicated capabilities

Culture Signals

Best Place to Work collapse: Rated #1 in federal government for 13 consecutive years (81.6/100 in 2024). Plummeted to 46.4/100 in 2025 - catastrophic drop reflecting workforce exodus, budget uncertainty, and cultural upheaval.

Voyager Declaration (July 2025): 287 scientists/employees publicly rebuked 'rapid and wasteful changes,' warning of weakened Technical Authority (safety oversight created after Columbia disaster), 'culture of organizational silence,' and risks to astronaut safety. Goddard Center Director resigned hours after letter published.

Chain-of-command tensions: Isaacman returning to strict hierarchy - but this has 'troubled history at NASA' (Columbia, Challenger disasters partly attributed to rigid hierarchies preventing safety concerns from reaching decision-makers).

Knowledge loss: With 4,000 employees departing, critical institutional knowledge about decades-old systems and safety protocols is walking out the door.

Contractor conversion: Plans to convert contractor positions to federal employees - massive workforce identity change.

SECTION 5

Recent News & Trigger Events

The following developments from the past 18 months create urgency and provide natural conversation entry points for engaging NASA.

1. 2025-05-01 - White House proposes 24% NASA budget cut to \$18.8B - smallest since 1961

Even though Congress rejected, the uncertainty paralyzed planning for months

2. 2025-07-26 - Voyager Declaration: 287 sign dissent letter; Goddard Director resigns

Organizational dysfunction McChrystal addresses - hierarchy silencing dissent, fear culture, threatened mission safety

3. 2025-07-26 - ~4,000 NASA employees depart through deferred resignation program (~20% workforce)

Massive organizational disruption - 20% knowledge loss requires fundamental redesign of how remaining workforce operates

4. 2025-09-01 - NASA terminates \$420M in consulting contracts (Booz Allen, Deloitte, Guidehouse, McKinsey)

Traditional consulting landscape cleared - no incumbent advisory firms. Field is open for McChrystal

5. 2025-12-17 - Jared Isaacman confirmed as 15th NASA Administrator (67-30 vote)

New administrator with commercial vision and military aviation background - natural McChrystal connection

6. 2026-03-24 - NASA 'Ignition' event: sweeping program restructuring, \$20B moon base plan, Gateway paused, Artemis redesigned

Most significant restructuring since post-Columbia era. Every center, directorate, program affected

SECTION 6

McChrystal Fit Assessment

Active trigger events (new administrator, 20% workforce loss, Ignition restructuring, Artemis grounding), clear economic buyer (Kshatriya), competitive landscape completely cleared, Isaacman-McChrystal military aviation connection. Budget exists (\$24.4B). Organizational urgency at maximum

Primary Problem

NASA must execute the most significant organizational transformation since its founding - consolidating centers, converting workforce, restructuring Artemis, building a moon base, pivoting to commercial - with 20% fewer people, new administrator with no government experience, demoralized workforce, weakened safety oversight, and active internal dissent

Best McChrystal Capability Fit

Distributed organization operating model across 10 centers; shared consciousness to replace rigid hierarchy (preventing Columbia/Challenger-type failures); workforce transformation; bridging entrepreneurial vision with government rigor; program execution under restructuring

Likely Objections to Engagement

We just cancelled all consulting contracts
Political sensitivity under current administration
Our problems are budget and political, not organizational
Isaacman's entrepreneurial orientation may resist structured advisory

Competitive Advisory Landscape

All four previous advisory firms terminated (Booz Allen, Deloitte, Guidehouse, McKinsey) - field cleared
Bryce Space (aerospace-specific)
Grant Thornton (government transformation)
Aerospace Safety Advisory Panel (safety input only)

SECTION 7

Conversation Entry Points

These questions are designed for a Senior Partner's first conversation. Each opens a thread that naturally leads to McChrystal Group's capabilities without a direct pitch.

1. You're implementing the Ignition vision across 10 centers with 20% fewer people and a workforce that just sent a public dissent letter about safety. How do you build shared consciousness across that distributed system when trust has been fractured?

For AA Kshatriya - addresses the core distributed-organization challenge

2. You ran Draken International - adversary air training requires the same kind of cross-organizational

coordination we built at JSOC. NASA's 10 centers are like 10 service branches that need to fight as one. What's your operating model for making that work?

For Isaacman - military aviation language he understands

3. The Voyager Declaration warned about weakened Technical Authority. That's exactly the kind of hierarchy failure we solved at JSOC - where dissent channels and shared consciousness prevent catastrophic decisions.

Safety culture angle - connects Columbia/Challenger history to McChrystal's methodology

Recommended Meeting Framing

Position as 'the organizational operating system for NASA's transformation' - Isaacman has the vision, Congress has the budget (\$24.4B), but implementation requires Team of Teams across 10 centers with a depleted, demoralized workforce. Frame around Columbia/Challenger parallel for safety culture.

SECTION 8

Brand Insights & Market Positioning

Brand strategy reveals organizational priorities and coordination challenges. The following analysis connects NASA's market positioning to potential McChrystal engagement opportunities.

Brand value: NASA consistently ranks as one of the most trusted US government brands - #1 in public favorability.

Identity evolution: Pivoting from 'NASA does' to 'NASA enables' - partnering with commercial companies rather than building/operating own systems. Fundamental identity shift creating internal tension.

Brand threats: Voyager Declaration publicly challenged leadership for the first time in decades. 20% exodus reinforces 'NASA in decline' narrative. Artemis delays damage 'NASA executes audacious missions' promise.

Brand gap: Promises audacious exploration (moon base, Mars) while reality is depleted workforce, grounded rocket, and organizational chaos. The gap between 'permanent moon base' announcement and 'can't fix a helium leak' is a brand credibility challenge.

McChrystal connection: NASA has the mission, budget (Congress stepped in), and vision (Isaacman's Ignition). What it lacks is the operating model to execute with 20% fewer people and fractured trust.

SECTION 9

Deep McChrystal Group Fit Analysis

This is the strategic case for pursuing NASA. It synthesizes findings from all previous sections into a comprehensive engagement thesis with specific fit dimensions, expected outcomes, stakeholder mapping, and a phased pursuit strategy.

9a. Fit Dimensions

Fit Dimension 1: Distributed Operating Model Across 10 Centers - Each center has deep institutional identity and autonomy. McChrystal uniquely positioned - this is the foundational JSOC problem of multiple organizations needing to function as one. McKinsey reorganizes org charts; McChrystal builds operating models for distributed organizations.

Fit Dimension 2: Safety Culture Restoration - Voyager Declaration warns of weakened Technical Authority. Columbia and Challenger resulted from rigid hierarchies suppressing dissent. McChrystal solved exactly this: maintaining hierarchy while creating shared consciousness where critical info reaches decision-makers regardless of rank.

Fit Dimension 3: Workforce Transformation - 4,000 departed + contractor-to-civil-service conversion. Remaining 14,000 must do work of 18,000. McChrystal's 'empowered execution' model designed for resource-constrained environments.

Fit Dimension 4: Bridging Entrepreneurial Vision and Government Operations - Isaacman brings 'move fast' mindset to 68-year safety-critical culture. McChrystal bridges military/government rigor with decisiveness and speed.

Fit Dimension 5: Program Execution Under Restructuring - Artemis II grounded while entire program restructured. Engineers must fix helium leaks while organizational context shifts beneath them.

9b. Cumulative Case

DOGE workforce reduction -> Budget crisis -> Voyager Declaration -> All consulting contracts terminated -> Isaacman confirmed -> Ignition restructuring -> Artemis II grounded -> Contractor conversion. Compound effect: most ambitious program since Apollo with most disrupted organization since founding.

Revenue potential: Phase 1 (\$1M-\$2M): Center coordination + leadership alignment | Phase 2 (\$2M-\$3.5M): Safety culture + Artemis execution | Phase 3 (\$2M-\$4M): Full agency embedding | Total: \$5M-\$9.5M

9c. Enterprise Issues

1. 10-Center coordination failure - duplicated capabilities, center-vs-HQ tension
2. Safety culture erosion - Voyager Declaration, weakened Technical Authority
3. Institutional knowledge hemorrhage - 20% workforce departure
4. Cultural collision: entrepreneurial administrator vs. safety-critical bureaucracy
5. Contractor-to-civil-service identity disruption
6. Artemis program execution amid total restructuring
7. Political whiplash and planning uncertainty
8. Distributed morale crisis (81.6 -> 46.4 satisfaction score)

9d. Expected Outcomes

1. 10-center shared consciousness - reduce cross-center decision time by 40-60%
2. Safety culture framework - dissent channels instrumented, safety concern escalation reduced to 48 hours
3. Artemis execution framework - zero additional cost growth from organizational friction

4. Workforce transformation integration - converted employees productive within 6 months, 85%+ retention
5. Administrator-civil service bridge - structured daily decision cycles replacing ad hoc communication
6. Knowledge preservation system - critical gaps identified across all 10 centers within 6 months
7. Distributed morale recovery - satisfaction scores from 46.4 toward 65+ within 18 months

9e. Key Stakeholders

Administrator

Leader: Jared Isaacman

Function: Vision, political direction

Relevance: Executive sponsor. Aviation background = McChrystal connection

Associate Administrator

Leader: Amit Kshatriya

Function: Operations across 10 centers

Relevance: PRIMARY TARGET

Deputy AA

Leader: Casey Swails

Function: Strategic direction, center coordination

Relevance: Key operational ally

Kennedy Space Center

Leader: Janet Petro

Function: Launch operations, Artemis

Relevance: SECONDARY TARGET - Army Colonel veteran

Space Security

Leader: Tom Cremins

Function: Military/intelligence coordination

Relevance: Network overlap with McChrystal

Exploration Systems

Leader: [TBD]

Function: SLS, Orion, landing systems

Relevance: Epicenter of Artemis restructuring

Science Directorate

Leader: [TBD]

Function: Earth/planetary science

Relevance: Survived budget threat, lowest morale

Goddard

Leader: [New director]

Function: Science missions

Relevance: Most disrupted center

Marshall

Leader: [TBD]

Function: SLS production, propulsion

Relevance: Owns the rocket with the helium leak

9f. Opportunity Thesis

Why Now: All consulting contracts terminated while the most ambitious reorganization in NASA history is underway. The field is cleared. 20% workforce loss + Ignition restructuring + Artemis grounding + Voyager Declaration = organizational crisis requiring external support.

Why McChrystal: Not a traditional consultancy (politically toxic at NASA now). Military/aviation credibility with Isaacman (Draken International). Proven distributed-organization model. Safety culture expertise (JSOC's lesson on dissent channels). Implementation, not advisory.

Phased Engagement: Phase 1 (6-9 months, \$1M-\$2M): Center coordination + Kshatriya team alignment | Phase 2 (12-18 months, \$2M-\$3.5M): Safety culture + Artemis framework | Phase 3 (18-24 months, \$2M-\$4M): Full agency transformation

Pursuit Map: Thread 1: Kshatriya via 10-center coordination challenge. Thread 2: Janet Petro (KSC, Army Colonel) via military veteran networks. Thread 3: Isaacman via military aviation/Draken connection - personal introduction through mutual contacts.